

FROM THE MAKERS OF THE FORGE AND WAR ROOM

COUNT ME IN



THE DARING LIFE *of a* JESUS FOLLOWER

*Travis Agnew with
Alex Kendrick & Stephen Kendrick*

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B&H
PUBLISHING®
BRENTWOOD, TENNESSEE

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Printed in the United States of America

979-8-3845-0074-2

Published by B&H Publishing Group
Brentwood, Tennessee

Dewey Decimal Classification: 248.83
Subject Heading: BIBLE. N.T. LUKE /
DISCIPLESHIP / CHRISTIAN LIFE

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Cover design and Illustration by Matt Stevens.

1 2 3 4 5 • 27 26 25 24

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DARING DISCIPLESHIP

Don't settle for following Jesus halfway.

IT'S CHALLENGING TO BE A teenager these days. Many students comment on the stress during these pivotal years, brought on by peer pressure, unending homework assignments, relational dramas, tempting situations, and demanding authority figures. Although this time of life has always been full of unique challenges for every generation, no doubt yours is experiencing an increasing amount of adversity. If you feel overwhelmed, we get it.

Being your age is challenging. But we want to offer a different type of challenge: in your journey from childhood to adulthood, what if you could thrive in the opportunity instead of just survive through the opposition? We hope and pray you live these years as a dedicated follower of Jesus, eagerly seeking His ways and diligently maturing in crucial areas. Don't waste these years; use them intentionally. If you do, you will grow by leaps and bounds spiritually and set the trajectory of your life on following Jesus intently.

Restraint Versus Responsibility

One of the most consistent hardships you feel during these years is probably the awkward tension between restraint and

responsibility. As you age, you will become more convinced you can handle situations independently. You don't think you need as many rules from your parents. You might inwardly think or verbally process that you know better than many authority figures in your life. Other people might bothersomely not agree that you are as capable as you feel.

In one sense, you might feel frustrated that some people still treat you like a child. In another sense, you don't want all the responsibilities of an adult, because some of those don't seem that fun. Some people annoy you by explaining too much, while others overwhelm you by expecting too much. The tension between restraint and responsibility can be exhausting.

Maybe you want more freedom when it comes to driving but less responsibility when it comes to cleaning. You want the ability to spend what you want but not be forced to work when you would rather not. The years between graduating elementary school and graduating high school are full of unbalanced expectations. At the heart of it, you probably feel frustrated when someone treats you like a child, because you should be respected as being closer to an adult than that. You want more responsibility, but you also want people to affirm your potential and to respect you.

Many people demand a lot from students but don't expect much. That's not the same with Jesus. If you've ever wanted someone to treat you with high expectations and provide you with exciting privileges, you've come to the right place. Jesus isn't waiting for you to get a job to develop a purpose. He's not waiting for you to move out on your own before He asks you to step out in faith. Do you want to be respected for what you can do at your age? Then get ready.

Reimagining the Teen Years

When Justin started following Jesus as a teenager, he went all in. He remembers the day of his baptism with sincere joy. He wasn't sure what was supposed to happen next, but he was eager to find out. Some mentors at his church helped him start his first Bible reading plan, connected him with other guys his age who wanted to grow, and answered his growing set of questions. Justin was most surprised, though, when his church gave him opportunities to serve. He thought that was just for adults who had gone to Bible college. But the church let him teach alongside a mentor, and he improved weekly.

Raising the bar in the church caused Justin to step up in his commitment to Jesus. He didn't try to hide his faith at school. He started being intentional with other teens who lived near him, always bringing a few of them along to church. He grew so quickly, and it was all because people around him expected him to do more than the bare minimum. Suppose Justin had waited until he was an adult before serving Christ seriously. Can you imagine how many people would have missed his example and impact?

Jesus doesn't limit your potential because of your youthfulness. If you are ready to follow Him now, He won't keep you in a waiting room until later. Your current "teen" label is a human invention, anyway, and a fairly recent one at that. Did you know that the word *teenager* wasn't in the dictionary until the 1940s? It wasn't a word because it wasn't needed. No "in-between" stage of life kept young people from becoming responsible adults, and growing maturity was expected from young people as soon as they left childhood behind.

Companies in the 1940s originated the word *teenager* to make money off that generation.¹ After the Great Depression, these companies saw a great opportunity to make money by targeting these newly coined *teenagers* with “must-have” products. The term became popular and began to represent people ages thirteen to eighteen who now wanted the same stuff as their peers to fit in.

Unlike these original teenagers, you don’t have to settle for years of mediocrity between childhood and adulthood. Why wait to do something great when God has used people your age many times before?

- Joseph was seventeen years old when God began showing him future events for which he needed to prepare (Genesis 37:2).
- Miriam was not even old enough for the youth group when she diligently watched over her baby brother Moses and created a brilliant plan while talking to a member of the intimidating royal family (Exodus 2:4-7).
- Samuel was a boy when God called him into service (1 Samuel 3:8).
- David’s father might have thought his son’s young age kept him from being considered for something important, but God thought David was just right for the job (1 Samuel 16:7, 11).
- When God enlisted the prophet Jeremiah to preach to God’s people at one of the most pivotal times in history, Jeremiah was still a youth (Jeremiah 1:6).

Those are only a few of the young people God used throughout Scripture. There are more! For thousands of years, young men and women around the world have continued to passionately pursue Christ. God doesn't want you to wait to be passionate about Him and His cause. You might grow up inactive and believe that's the norm, but that would be a shame! Even if your peers or authority figures remain spiritually lazy, that doesn't have to be your standard. Jesus is too great and glorious to follow Him halfway.

Youthful Example

The apostle Paul believed a young man named Timothy was far more capable than most people would have given someone his age credit for. Paul watched Timothy transform from a young boy learning from his godly mother and grandmother into a bold pastor with reliable character (2 Timothy 1:5; 4:2).

Part of Timothy's growth was due to Paul's influence. Timothy was both a disciple of Jesus and a disciple of Paul. Jesus had ascended to heaven before Timothy ever got to meet Him, but Timothy knew Him very well. How? Because Paul told his young disciple what Jesus was like. Paul and Timothy were so close that Paul called him his "true son in the faith" (1 Timothy 1:2). It was one mentor giving everything he had to one follower. They called it discipleship.

This is the context for one of the most repeated Bible verses in youth groups worldwide. As Timothy stepped into ministry leadership, Paul wrote to him, "Don't let anyone despise your youth, but set an example for the believers in speech, in conduct, in love, in faith, and in purity" (1 Timothy

4:12). It was Paul's loving yet bold warning to his young disciple: don't let your age be an excuse for slacking off.

Paul knew Jesus could use Timothy, even if others didn't think he was old enough yet. Timothy wasn't the backup option because the starter injured himself. Paul wouldn't let Timothy waste pivotal years of youthful energy combined with maturing discipleship. The time was too valuable and the possibility too remarkable. Timothy wasn't the church of the future; he was the church of the present, and Paul was ready for Timothy to be a leader within it.

Like Timothy, you can be an example to all people, regardless of their age. Paul told Timothy exactly how to affect those who observed his life: let the content of your words (speech) and the character of your life (conduct) be done with the right motive (love), with the right focus (faith), and in the right way (purity). Paul's call to Timothy is the same one God is giving you through His Word. Don't misuse these years on lesser pursuits. Avoid responding to God with a list of excuses for why you can't do anything now. The Almighty God can work mightily through willing young people, including you.

If you feel willing but unprepared, you might be missing a critical component: discipleship. Before Jesus ascended into heaven, He commanded His followers to go and make disciples (Matthew 28:19). The term *disciple* means "student." A disciple is someone who desires to learn a certain way of living from a trustworthy example. Jesus calls His followers to teach others "to observe everything I have commanded you" (Matthew 28:20).

Maybe you are saved, but has someone discipled you? Jesus called us to make disciples, not converts. Following

Jesus is more than saying a prayer, raising a hand, getting baptized, or kneeling at an altar. Your baptism is an important step, but it shouldn't be the last one. You were baptized publicly to announce to people in the room, "The work is now beginning; keep me accountable," not "The job is done; leave me alone."

Discipleship requires more than a momentary commitment with no follow-through. We've all had moments of sincere motivation to make changes. Maybe you felt the pull to continue your positive trends as camp wrapped up last summer. You might have heard a sermon that convicted you to make a lasting change. Or maybe someone else's example encouraged you to be and do more.

You felt those urges. You knew there were things you should start doing. You were convinced there were some things you should stop doing.

But it's one thing to say you want to follow Jesus and another to do it. Responding to the gospel happens in a moment. Following Jesus as His disciple, though, will continue throughout your life. Discipleship means admitting you have been changed by grace but still desire change by growth. Embracing discipleship is the honest acknowledgment that you have room to grow and eagerly desire to do so.

Peter is Jesus's most famous disciple. He is well known for his amazing accomplishments and his embarrassing failures. After three years of following Jesus, Peter had a moment to prove himself. Jesus had been arrested, and a young girl identified Peter as one of Jesus's disciples. Instead of boldly stepping forward in faith, he denied Jesus in fear. Peter should have been standing beside Jesus, but he was warming himself beside a fire (John 18:18), more focused on his comfort than Christ.

The next time we see Peter standing near a fire, he wasn't running from Jesus. He was running toward Him (John 21:7). Jesus rose from the grave and still sought out the disciples who had abandoned Him. He called to them while they were in a boat fishing. Peter didn't try to walk on water this time; he plunged into the sea and swam the rest of the way. As he approached the shore, he saw Jesus, who was cooking breakfast over a fire. The scene had to be eerily familiar. It likely jogged Peter's memory. As he stared at a reminder of when he gave into fear, situated next to the Savior he had failed, Peter probably was at a loss for what to say.

Maybe you feel you have failed Jesus when it counted the most too. Let this scene by the fire remind you that Jesus hasn't given up on you. He is willing to move past moments of letdowns and provide second chances. Jesus calls each of us to discipleship—not perfection. Even if your past is full of missed opportunities, there's a Savior on the shore inviting you to sit by Him at the fire and give following Him another shot.

No matter what has happened in the past, what will you do now? Many students say they follow Jesus, but only the ones who keep moving toward Him are serious about their commitment. We invite you to sign up for the most life-changing experience and Jesus's world-changing plan. Will you say "yes" to Jesus's daring life of true discipleship?

How to Read This Book

Where will you begin? We want you to look at the life of the master disciple-maker Himself, Jesus. In this book, we will highlight eight priorities Jesus gave His disciples. You will also see these priorities for yourself by reading the Gospel of Luke,

which gives an account of Jesus's life and His discipleship of others. Luke has twenty-four chapters, so you will read three chapters in Luke's Gospel for each chapter in *Count Me In*. We will guide your reading and show you what to look for as you go through each section of Scripture.

If you read this book on your own, we applaud that you're prioritizing discipleship. Your best chance to succeed at being one of Jesus's disciples, though, is by having people in your life who are at least aware of your process, if not joining you in it. Do you have a discipleship mentor (parent, pastor, coach, teacher) or a friend? You could read this book with a group or another person, or you could share what you are learning with your mentor or someone you are discipling.

Some people your age will hear this call and think they are too young. They might say, "Count me out," because they don't think they're ready. Another's response could sound like, "Count me in later," because they have more pressing pursuits. But don't you want something more? If Jesus is this captivating (and He is!), why would you wait to follow Him?

Will you say, "Count me in!" to a daring life as a Jesus follower? If so, take the next step in your discipleship by joining us in reading the Gospel of Luke and working through this book. ~*~

1. <https://dp.la/exhibitions/children-progressive-era/childhood-postwar-america/teenage-culture#>

Today's students are constantly pulled toward a life of confusion and half-baked beliefs. But Jesus Christ is calling them to something greater than anything this world can offer. He offers eternal life that includes a living relationship with God, a radical commitment to truth, and a life of love, compassion, and purpose. A radical life that counts now and in eternity.

Count Me In walks students through the entire Gospel of Luke and Jesus's bold invitation to follow Him daily, obey Him faithfully, and trust Him completely. The chapters focus on eight important elements of discipleship, from studying Scripture to sharing Jesus with others.

Students will be challenged with:

- *Do I value the right relationships?*
- *Do I have a healthy perspective of my earthly stuff?*
- *Do I let temptation and sin block my spiritual growth?*
- *Do I have a plan to keep my life intentionally grounded in Christ?*

Including reflection questions and discussion guides, this book can easily work for solo readers or group studies. Students should feel inspired to take on a deeper study of Scripture and challenged to take Christ's call of discipleship seriously in their own lives.

Jesus chose young followers in the first century and invites today's generation of young people to follow Him now. To know Him, love Him, and make Him known. To surrender and put Him first in every area. To be a part of His message and His mission to the nations. *Count Me In* will engage students to hear the amazing call of Jesus and to boldly live out their faith every day.

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979-8-3845-0074-2 \$17.99 USD

